

THE COMMON TONE

Brand Brief

Where the Sacred and the Profane Share the Same Cup

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thecommontone.com

Who We Are

The Common Tone is a music theory enterprise built by Doug Smith — a music professor, composer, and performer. At its heart is a textbook called *The Sound and the Theory*, a comprehensive popular music theory text that treats classical tradition and popular, blues, and jazz idioms with equal reverence.

But this is more than a textbook. It is the central node of an interconnected enterprise: a textbook, a four-course university curriculum, a YouTube channel, a Substack newsletter, a website with interactive tools, and a growing social media presence. Every part shares the same intellectual DNA and the same brand identity.

The Core Idea

In music, a common tone is the single pitch shared between two chords — the thread that holds a modulation together, the note that belongs to both worlds at once.

That's what this brand is: the common ground between the scholarly and the accessible, the classical and the popular, the rigorous and the inviting.

What Makes This Project Different

The Sound and the Theory is not a conventional textbook that forces pop music into classical boxes. Doug has developed a set of original theoretical contributions that give the book a distinctive intellectual identity:

- **The Plagal Paradigm:** A reframing of harmonic function that treats the I–IV axis as a co-equal partner to the traditional I–V axis. The grammar of gospel, folk, rock, and much of the world's music, finally given its due.
- **Graded Closure:** A nine-level taxonomy of how music arrives — not a binary “cadence or not,” but a spectrum of arrival strength.
- **Stream Leading:** A framework for understanding modern pop texture as four functional layers (Beat, Bass, Filler, Melody) rather than four-part chorale writing.
- **The Herald:** The concept that form in popular music is articulated by texture and rhythm — drum fills, guitar licks, strategic silences — as much as by harmony.

These are not minor variations on existing theory. They are original contributions that position The Common Tone as a distinctive voice in the field.

The Enterprise

The enterprise has six properties, all connected. The textbook is the foundation — the thing that earns the right to everything else. Each platform transforms the material for its native medium.

Property	Role	Audience
The Sound and the Theory (textbook)	The Authority. The definitive work.	University students, serious self-learners
thecommontone.com (website)	The Hub. Central nervous system. Links everything together.	Everyone — the front desk
Pop Music Theory Hub (website section)	The Workshop. Interactive tools, exercises, song database.	Students, teachers, self-learners, curious musicians
Substack newsletter	The Depth. Extended essays, serialized chapters, community.	Engaged readers, fellow theorists
YouTube channel	The Discovery Engine. The front door. Visual, audible, shareable.	Broadest audience — casual to serious
Social media (X, Instagram, Reddit)	The Signal. Provocations, quotes, conversation, visual content.	Music theory community, musicians, educators

How Content Flows

Ideas originate in the textbook research and flow outward, transformed for each platform:

Textbook (the definitive treatment) → **Substack** (the essay — expands, editorializes) → **YouTube** (the demonstration — makes it audible and visible) → **Social** (the signal — distills to a single compelling moment)

The flow also reverses: audience questions and engagement feed back into the research and the book. A Reddit thread can surface a better way to explain something. A YouTube comment can reveal a common misconception worth addressing.

The Brand Identity

Aesthetic

In three words: **Warm. Scholarly. Grounded.**

Dark Academia, but not cosplay. This is a real scholar’s desk — worn wood, good light, ink that’s actually been used. The aesthetic should feel like a place where serious work happens and where you’d also want to have a drink.

Color Palette

Role	Color	Hex	Usage
Primary Dark	Obsidian	#1A1A2E	Backgrounds, primary text
Primary Warm	Amber / Gold	#D4A843	Accents, highlights, links
Secondary Warm	Parchment	#F5F0E8	Light backgrounds, cards
Secondary Cool	Slate	#4A4A6A	Secondary text, borders
Accent	Deep Burgundy	#8B2332	Emphasis, key terms
Success	Muted Sage	#6B7F5E	Confirmations, tags

Note: These are working values. Final palette to be confirmed during brand development.

Typography

Context	Typeface	Notes
Print headings	Futura Condensed ExtraBold	Established house style
Print body	Gill Sans	Established house style
Web headings	Playfair Display (Bold)	Serif — scholarly authority
Web body	Lato or Open Sans	Clean, readable sans-serif
Social overlays	Futura Condensed ExtraBold	Matches print for brand continuity

Logo and Wordmark

Status: Needs to be developed.

The name “The Common Tone” is inherently musical and conceptual — a shared pitch between two chords. The mark should evoke connection, overlap, and shared ground without being literal music-note

clip art. It must work at avatar scale (32×32px) and at print scale, and it should feel warm and scholarly — not corporate, not whimsical.

Platform Visual Specs

Status: Needs to be developed — blocked by logo/wordmark.

Once the core identity is locked, templates are needed for: YouTube thumbnails and channel banner, Substack headers, Instagram feed and story templates, X header and post images, and website hero/card layouts. The governing principle: every thumbnail, header, card, and avatar should be recognizably from the same family at a glance.

The Voice

Doug Smith is always Doug Smith. But the room changes the register. The core voice — scholarly, warm, precise, comic when the moment allows — is the constant. What shifts is the density, the formality, and the tempo.

By Platform

Textbook: Full scholarly. The complete instrument. Etymological depth, narrative personas, multi-layered argument. Can be long and complex when the idea demands it. Never talks down, never apologizes for complexity.

Substack: Essayistic. The professor writing for peers and enthusiasts. Can pursue a single idea at length — the digressions are the point. More literary than the textbook. Publishes when the essay is ready, not on a forced schedule.

YouTube: Performative-scholarly. The good lecture hall — the one you don't skip. First 15 seconds must hook, but never rushed. The pacing of a good storyteller. Seasonal rhythm, roughly weekly.

X / Twitter: Aphoristic. The sharpest version of the idea. One insight per post. Punchy but never glib. Never dunks, never engages in bad-faith arguments.

Instagram: Visual-first. The image carries the idea, the caption deepens it. Etymology cards, notation graphics, form maps, pull quotes. Each post should feel curated, not churned out.

Reddit: Collegial. A knowledgeable peer, not an authority descending from above. Answers with depth and specificity. Never self-promotes without adding value.

Example Register (X/Twitter)

“The IV chord doesn't want to go home. It's already there.”

That's the Common Tone voice compressed to its sharpest point: a provocation grounded in real theory, delivered with warmth and a little swagger.

Content Rhythm

The enterprise does not run on a rigid editorial calendar. The rhythm is organic and development-driven — content flows outward when the work produces something worth sharing.

Cadence

Platform	Cadence	Notes
Substack	When the essay is ready	Quality-driven, not schedule-driven
YouTube	Seasonal, roughly weekly	Bursts during active phases, quieter during deep work
Social (original posts)	A couple times per week	Does not include engagement/replies
Social (engagement)	Ongoing, opportunistic	Replies, threads, conversations — always on

The Organic Campaign Model

Rather than a traditional content calendar, the enterprise runs on development-driven campaigns. A campaign is triggered when something real happens — a chapter reaches a milestone, a new tool launches on the website, a theoretical concept crystallizes.

When a trigger fires, content flows organically across platforms as a natural wave. For example, completing a major chapter might generate a Substack essay expanding one aspect, social posts with a provocative question or etymology graphic, and a YouTube video demonstrating the concept with real songs. A smaller milestone might produce only a post or two. The system makes it easy to see what each trigger could generate, without mandating that it must.

Social Media Presence

The Hybrid Persona Model

The social media presence operates as a hybrid. Doug posts personally when he wants to — the original provocations, the personal stories, the opinions that only he can voice. An AI-assisted persona handles routine engagement, scheduled visual content, and discovery, with everything going through a review queue before posting.

What Doug Handles Personally

- Original intellectual observations and provocations
- Personal stories from teaching, performing, and composing
- Responses to sensitive or high-profile conversations
- All YouTube and Substack content
- Anything where a wrong note would damage the brand

What the Persona Handles (with Doug's Review)

- Scheduled content — etymology cards, notation graphics, form maps, pull quotes
- Discovery — finding relevant conversations and flagging them for Doug
- Drafting replies to straightforward theory questions
- Cross-platform content adaptation from Substack or YouTube
- Routine engagement — liking, sharing, bookmarking relevant content

The Persona Never Acts Autonomously On

- Opinions on controversial topics
- Corrections of other people's analyses
- Anything that sounds like Doug making a personal claim
- Engagement in heated debates
- Original theoretical content not already published

The Website: thecommontone.com

The website is the hub. It has three layers:

The Front Door — The public-facing landing that introduces Doug, the book, and the brand. Clean, warm, authoritative. Answers “who is this?” and “why should I care?” and connects visitors to all other properties.

The Content Layer — Blog posts, essays, curated video collections, a growing library of articles. Establishes The Common Tone as a destination, not just a storefront.

The Tool Layer: Pop Music Theory Hub — An expanding collection of interactive tools that live as a dedicated section of the site. Exercise generators tied to textbook chapters, analysis tools (form mapping, harmonic overlays), generation tools (chord progressions that respect the book’s grammar), and eventually a searchable song database drawn from the research archive.

The Song Database Opportunity

The research archive contains detailed analytical entries for hundreds of songs. If made public and searchable, this becomes a powerful discovery engine — people Google song analyses constantly and mostly find shallow results.

Someone searching “Radiohead Creep chord analysis” lands on a rich, thoughtful entry — and now they’re in the ecosystem.

Where We Need Help

The intellectual identity, the voice, the content architecture, and the enterprise structure are well defined. What the project needs from a marketing partner:

Brand Development

- Logo and wordmark design that embodies the brand’s warm scholarly identity
- Platform-specific visual templates (YouTube, Instagram, Substack, X, website)
- Finalized color palette confirmation

Audience Strategy

- Identifying and reaching the primary audiences: university music students and faculty, self-taught musicians, songwriters and producers, music-curious general audience
- Platform-specific growth strategy (which platform gets investment first?)
- SEO and discoverability for the website and song database

Launch and Campaign Strategy

- Coordinated launch plan as properties come online
- Framework for the organic campaign model — how to operationalize development-driven content waves
- Social media growth strategy that respects the brand's quality-over-quantity ethos

Business Model Guidance

- Pop Music Theory Hub: free tools as a discovery engine, freemium, bundled with textbook, or hybrid?
- Substack: free, paid, or hybrid tiers?
- Website monetization and sustainability model



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